

and heating. The phone also comes with UFS 3.1 storage instead of UFS 4.0 which makes the read and write speeds slower than the competition.

For gaming, it's a bit hit or miss. Casual games and short sessions are smooth, but if you're into long gaming marathons on high-demand games like BGMI or Call of Duty: Mobile, you'll notice some frame drops and heat buildup, which is a bummer for a high-end phone.

On the software side, the Pixel 9 ships with Android 14, not the latest Android 15, which is a slight disappointment. However, Google promises seven years of Android OS updates, which is pretty great. The software experience is classic Pixel – clean, straightforward, and free of unnecessary bloatware.

The interface is smooth, especially with the 120Hz refresh rate turned on, making everyday use feel pretty snappy. So, while it might not blow away the competition in raw performance, the Pixel 9's software optimizations keep things running smoothly for the most part.

AI FEATURES AND SCORE

If you're into AI, the Pixel 9 is where it's at. This phone is packed with some seriously mindblowing AI features that genuinely enhance the user experience. New additions like the "Add Me" feature make sure you never miss out on group photos, and "Reimagine" lets you tweak entire sections of a photo, which is great for getting creative. "Auto Frame" helps you capture the best shots without much effort.

Other handy AI tools like Pixel Weather's smart summaries and the Pixel Studio app for making AI-generated images show how Google is all about integrating AI into daily use. "Circle to Search" and the new screen-shots app make managing content a breeze, and a free month of Gemini Advanced gives you a taste of conversational AI.

The Pixel 9 scores a solid 85/100 in AI benchmarks, thanks to its strong

performance in this area. All in all, it's a leader in AI capabilities, with features that actually add value and make the phone more fun and functional.

CAMERAS

The Pixel 9 continues to deliver on the camera front, though it doesn't bring any major upgrades over the Pixel 8. The main camera setup remains unchanged, but there's a new ultra-wide camera and autofocus for selfies. The lack of a dedicated telephoto lens and the absence of a Pro mode might be a letdown for serious photographers looking for more control.

In good lighting, the main camera shines, capturing detailed images with natural sharpening and well-balanced colours, though there's a slightly cool tone. The dynamic range is solid, ensuring photos have a nice balance between bright and dark areas. Portrait mode could use a bit of work, though; the background blur is sometimes a bit too strong, and edge detection isn't always perfect.

Without a telephoto lens, the Pixel 9 relies on digital zoom, which is fine up to 2x but gets pretty grainy beyond that, especially in low light. The ultra-wide camera is a nice addition, delivering sharp, vibrant images with good dynamic range, and it also doubles as a macro lens for those close-up shots – just be careful with focus due to the shallow depth of field.

Selfies have definitely improved with the new autofocus feature, resulting in clearer, more vibrant shots with accurate skin tones. In low-light situations, the Pixel 9's cameras still manage to pull off decent photos with good colour preservation, though there's some noise in darker areas like night skies. Video recording is stable and clear, but it's missing the Video Boost feature that's available on the Pro models, which is a bit of a downer.

Overall, the Pixel 9's camera system is versatile and dependable, capable of delivering great photos in various conditions, making it a strong competitor among flagship phones.

BATTERY LIFE

Battery life on the Google Pixel 9 is pretty solid, with noticeable improvements over the previous model. The 4700 mAh battery provides around 6-6.5 hours of screen-on time for heavy users, making it reliable for a full day's use. It performed exceptionally well in the PCMark Battery Test, clocking in at 14 hours and 45 minutes, which is great for a phone of this size.

However, charging speeds aren't its strong suit – it takes about 1 hour and 27 minutes to fully charge. On the plus side, it supports wireless charging and reverse wireless charging, adding some flexibility.

VERDICT

The Google Pixel 9 is the best compact AI phone of 2024, so far. It brings an impressive array of AI features that set it apart, making it a standout device for those who value innovative software. But, there are some misses. While the Tensor G4 chip shows improved performance, it still lags behind its competitors and the heating issues, while fewer, still persist. The camera system delivers solid results, especially in daylight, but lacks some pro-level features. And the display, though vibrant, lacks flagship specifications. Overall, the Pixel 9 is a great choice for AI enthusiasts and those seeking a clean Android experience. There's tons of AI goodness and actually useful features here. But Google really needs to improve its performance to make a mark among gamers and power users.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Google Tensor G4 | OS: Android 14 | RAM: 12 GB LPDDR5X | Storage: 256 GB UFS 3.1 | Cameras (rear): 50 MP Primary + 48 MP Ultrawide | Selfie camera: 10.5 MP | Display: 6.3" OLED, 1080 x 2424 pixels | Display Refresh Rate: 120 Hz | Display protection: Gorilla Glass Victus 2 | IP rating: IP68 | Battery: 4,700 mAh | Charging: 27 W wired, 15 W wireless, Reverse Wireless

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